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government shouldn't seek to hasten the process but instead should respect the wishes of the populace. In their view, the maintenance of the state's autonomy is the surest guarantee against the rise of secessionist sentiment.

Both positions have flaws. To grasp the problems, a brief historical excursus is in order. The Maharaja of Kashmir, Hari Singh, failed to accede to India or Pakistan under the British departure's terms. But with Pakistan-backed tribals on the outskirts of Srinagar at the end of October 1947, he turned to India for help and agreed to accede in exchange for military assistance. Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru, concerned about the legality and legitimacy of the accession, sought the advice of Sheikh Mohammed Abdullah, leader of the largest popular organisation within the state, the Jammu and Kashmir National Conference (NC), before accepting the accession. Only with Abdullah's imprimatur did Nehru send in troops to relieve the beleaguered monarch.

Subsequently, under the Delhi Agreement of 1952, between Abdullah and Nehru, the hereditary monarchy was abolished, residuary powers were vested in the state, special provisions were drawn up for state subjects and particular features of the Indian Constitution were deemed inapplicable to Kashmir (for example, Emergency powers could only be extended to Kashmir in wartime). It is unclear whether the Delhi Agreement would have stood the test of time had Abdullah not been dismissed in 1953 under some murky circumstances.

Despite his high-handed methods of governance, Abdullah and the NC commanded a certain stature in the state because of their historic opposition to the Maharaja's corrupt rule. His successor, Bakshi Ghulam Mohammed didn't command popular support nor did he have much regard for democratic practices. Keen on obtaining developmental assistance of the Central government to bolster support from his constituency, Bakshi integrated the state into the Indian Union. His regime went along with the Central government's decision to extend the Union List of the Constitution to J&K while exempting the matters of the ownership of immovable properties and the special powers of the J&K High Court. The material benefits accrued to the state weren't insubstantial. During his term the first engineering, agricultural and medical colleges

were created. Bakshi's successor Ghulam Mohammed Sadiq proved less authoritarian. He brought a degree of probity and fairness in dealings with the Opposition. He continued the trend towards integration. Under his watch, Articles 356 and 357 of the Constitution, which permit the President to take over the governance of the state in the event of an emergency, were extended to J&K. It was also decided that Parliament members would be elected directly and not nominated by the state Assembly. These and other changes, such as the re-designation of the prime minister of the state as chief minister, made the state's status in relationship to the Central government similar to other Indian states. The propensity of various Congress regimes to secure a foothold in the state through any means culminated in the flawed elections of 1987. A markedly politically sophisticated and mobilised generation of Kashmiris, lacking institutional means of dissent, resorted to violence. Sensing an opportunity to wreak havoc, Benazir Bhutto's regime in Pakistan jumped into the fray transforming a domestic uprising into a full-blown, externally manipulated, ideologically-charged extortion racket.

Since the outbreak of insurgency, the forging of a deft counter-insurgency strategy coupled with free and fair elections, especially in 2002, has restored some semblance of normalcy. That said, the question of the state's relations with the Central government remains in abeyance. The restoration of the state's autonomy to the terms of the Delhi Agreement is probably politically infeasible today.

Moreover, such an agreement would do little to assuage the legitimate misgivings of the minority populations in Ladakh and Jammu. From Sheikh Abdullah's initial regime to the present day, these "nested minorities"—minorities within a larger national minority—have had deep reservations about most regimes in Srinagar.

Consequently, they have preferred the steady integration of the state with India. Their concerns, however, cannot be allowed to override the equally legitimate fears of unwarranted Central government interference in the affairs of the state. The task before the interlocutors of the state and the Central government, then, is to carefully balance these two competing interests as the country seeks to forge a viable and sustainable relationship with its only Muslim-majority state.

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JAWAHARLAL NEHRU, to Liaqat Ali Khan, 1947

"The question of aiding Kashmir in this emergency is not designed to influence the state to accede."